For most places he visits, Xuanzang records their size, salient features of their geography, their rulers, occasional individual or cultural quirks, agricultural and other products, local legends and more. Most kings, he observes, were male Kshatriyas, Vaishyas, Brahmins or Buddhists. But he records some exceptions too. In the country of Brahmapura in the lower Himalayas, where people are 'hasty and impetuous', a woman has for ages 'been the ruler, and so it is called the kingdom of the women. The husband of the reigning woman is called king, but he knows nothing about the affairs of the state. The men manage the wars and sow the land, and that is all'. In a country near Bijnor, a Shudra king 'worships the spirits of heaven'. Its 'sincere and truthful' people revere 'learning, and are deeply versed in the use of charms and magic'. In Sindh too, which abounds with Buddhists, the king is a Shudra, 'by nature honest and sincere' and reverential towards the Buddha. Matipura, near Haridwar, has a Shudra king as well.

In Kannauj, the prosperous realm of Harsha, people are honest, noble and 'gracious in appearance'. Harsha had earlier greatly expanded his domain via six years of war 'by subduing all who were not obedient'. At some point, he embraced Buddhism, banned all animal slaughter for food and made violations thereof punishable by death. He joined religious debates, 'rewarded the good and punished the evil' and promoted 'men of talent'. Xuanzang admires Harsha's religious piety, temperance and generosity. 'Every fifth year, he convoked a grand assembly of deliverance (*Maha-moksha-parishad)*, and distributed the stores of his treasuries in charity' to 'the poor, the orphans, the destitute' and religious institutions. 'In all the highways of the towns and villages throughout India he erected hospices, provided food and drink, and stationed there physicians, with medicines for travelers and poor persons round about, to be given without any stint.'[18]

Xuanzang also visits Ayodhya, where people are 'virtuous and amiable'. A hundred Buddhist monasteries host 3000 monks, he writes. Non-Buddhists are 'few in number' and have ten temples. Ayodhya, this suggests, is largely a Buddhist town in the seventh century. In early fifth century (c. 406 CE), Faxian too writes about visiting its many sacred Buddhist sites. Ayodhya's flourishing Buddhist scene in the fifth century lures Vasubandhu, a monk from Gandhara, who moves here, becomes a great Buddhist master and teacher and breathes new life into the Yogacara